Michael Lopez

Data Leader · Civic Tech & Social Impact

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Policy-trained data scientist working on housing, public safety, and benefits delivery. I build the measurement itself: a rental supply-gap model published annually, a community-resource index that helped direct a $1.25B bond package, and citywide spatial risk models a city agency used to decide where to work.

EXPERIENCE

Child Poverty Action Lab DALLAS, TX · 2020 – PRESENT

Director, Data Operations — Jan 2026 – Present

- Lead CPAL's data platform migration to Databricks (Unity Catalog, Workflows, Lakebase + Lakehouse on AWS, Git-tracked orchestration), systematizing around 40 pipelines from file-based storage onto unified cloud infrastructure
- Built AI-enabled team workflows (Claude Code with custom skills and agents, prompt caching with the Anthropic API), including multi-agent code review with independent verification, accelerating how we develop pipelines, write documentation, review code, and communicate with stakeholders
- Maintain the eviction data workstream across four North Texas counties (~48,000 Dallas filings in 2025), feeding 12+ partners daily including the Dallas Eviction Advocacy Center and the Princeton Eviction Lab

Director, Data — May 2023 – Dec 2025

- Helped build CPAL's data operations from a single analyst to a team of 2–4 reporting to me; led hiring for the org's first data engineer and prior analyst roles
- Directed CPAL's citywide risk terrain modeling through 2024; division-level findings informed Office of Integrated Public Safety Solutions deployment and drove blight-remediation site selection and neighborhood amenity construction
- Modeled Dallas's rental supply gap for CPAL's annual Rental Housing Needs Assessment (2023–2024): a 33,660-unit shortfall at or below 50% AMI, projected to 83,500 by 2030
- Led a 30+ app suite of decision-support tools, built mostly in-house with external consulting partners, spanning housing, public safety, maternal health, benefits delivery, and criminal justice

Manager, Data — May 2022 – May 2023

- Ran CPAL's citywide risk terrain modeling on Dallas PD incident data joined to Data Axle property and business records (SIMSI), producing division-level environmental risk surfaces to target place-based violence prevention
- Led development of R Shiny applications, shifting the organization toward interactive data products

Associate, Data — Jun 2020 – Apr 2022

- Created the initial eviction data pipeline in R, laying the groundwork for the system now serving four North Texas counties
- Built the Community Resource Explorer, indexing community-resource access within two miles of every Dallas school campus to find the least-resourced neighborhoods; helped define disbursement of a $1.25B bond package
- Developed dashboards and reports in R, QGIS, Tableau, and ArcGIS for internal teams and community partners
- Presented findings on housing instability, afterschool programming, and public safety to partner organizations

EARLIER LEADERSHIP & POLICY EXPERIENCE

Health and Social Policy Intern, Children at Risk — Jun 2019 – Aug 2019

Led policy research on early childhood development and developed policy briefs for senior leadership and state stakeholders.

Research Coordinator, University of Texas at Dallas — Aug 2016 – Dec 2018

Managed the Developmental Neurolinguistics Lab; recruited, trained, and supervised 10–15 research assistants each semester and 300+ participants.

SKILLS

Methods	Risk Terrain Modeling · Index Construction & PCA · Spatial Analysis · Needs Assessment & Supply Modeling
Analysis & Languages	R (tidyverse, sf, Shiny) · SQL · Python · TypeScript
Visualization & Geospatial	R Shiny · Tableau · Mapbox GL · Spatial SQL · QGIS · ArcGIS
Domains	Housing & Eviction · Public Safety · Criminal Justice · Maternal Health · Benefits Delivery · Community Development
Data Platform	Databricks (Lakehouse + Unity Catalog) · PostgreSQL / Neon · DuckDB · Polars · PostGIS · CKAN
AI Workflows	Claude Code (custom skills & agents) · Anthropic API · Google Cloud Vision (OCR)

EDUCATION

Master of Public Policy, University of Texas at Dallas

Bachelor of Arts, Psychology & Anthropology, Florida International University

SELECTED PROJECTS

- **Dallas County Eviction Data.** Daily eviction-filing feed reaching 12+ legal-aid and outreach partners; ~48,000 Dallas filings a year turned into tenant outreach.
- **Parcel Block Walking Tool.** Field-outreach tool flagging homes likely missing a homestead exemption; ~20 active field-team users across outreach partners.
- **DigiLab** digilab.cards**.** Community-sourced tournament data platform for the Digimon and Gundam card game scenes; 11,000+ tournaments and 19,000+ players tracked, built and run solo through agentic workflows.

SELECTED MEDIA

- **The Lab Report:** Data visualizations for Dallas homeless-enforcement and patrol-staffing analyses (2026)
- **D Magazine:** “The Lawyer Who Landlords Don’t Want to See in Court” (2024)
- **KERA News:** “Eviction less likely for Dallas County tenants who get a lawyer” (2024)